



Lu Sun <lusun8825@gmail.com>

Re: Project Pitch 00118188

Lindsay Portnoy <lportnoy@salesforce.nsf.gov>

Mon, Jul 13, 2026 at 1:41 PM

To: "lportnoy@salesforce.nsf.gov" <lportnoy@salesforce.nsf.gov>, "lusun8825@gmail.com" <lusun8825@gmail.com>

**Project Pitch: 00118188****Topic Area: SBIR/STTR: Learning and Cognition Technologies (LC)****Invite Date: 7/13/2026**

Dear Lu,

Upon reviewing your submitted Project Pitch, I am pleased **to invite you to submit a full Phase I proposal** to the U.S. National Science Foundation's (NSF) Small Business Innovation Research (SBIR)/Small Business Technology Transfer (STTR) program.

Your full proposal (based on the project proposed in the associated Project Pitch) must be submitted **within the submission window that is active on the date of your invitation or within the subsequent submission window that is offered**. In other words, you must submit your full proposal to one of the next two announced deadlines. A full list of submission window deadlines can be found in the current Phase I solicitation, which can be found here: <https://seedfund.nsf.gov/solicitations/>. If the currently-posted solicitation does not offer two future solicitation window deadlines, you will be allowed to submit your proposal to submission windows that are offered in the next Phase I solicitation.

This invitation can only be used for one full proposal submission (i.e. cannot be used as the basis for more than one Phase I full proposal). Note that this invitation permits full proposal submission to the [standard NSF Phase I solicitation](#), but not to the [new pilot solicitation focused on Scientific Instrumentation](#).

More information about the Phase I full proposal can be found at the below links:

NSF SBIR/STTR Phase I Solicitation
Detailed Guidance on Full Proposal Preparation
NSF SBIR/STTR Eligibility

Please submit your proposal to the **Learning and Cognition Technologies (LC)** topic as soon as you are ready. If applicable, additional guidance to consider as you develop your proposal is given below.

Dear Lu,

Please submit your proposal to the Learning and Cognition Technologies topic when you are ready. Be sure to include sufficient technical details in the experimental plan along with specific milestones and quantitative success metrics and details of how you will achieve the desired outcomes. Our proposals are not pitches for ideas, they are thorough plans that you will execute so the 7-10 page R&D plan should spend most of the pages on how/what experiments/what might not work and why and what might be an alternative approach, etc. Follow the guidelines in the Project Description portion of our revised and most recent solicitation (see here: <https://seedfund.nsf.gov/solicitation-proposal/>) and this document: https://hw898.ise.msstate.edu/files/research_101_for_engineers.pdf. Some points to consider as you develop the content for your proposal include:

Technical:

1. What are the key technology risks/problems specific to your approach (not the market or industry problems, but problems with your technology that are preventing it from achieving the desired results)?
2. What is the proposed innovation to solving the problems? If there has been work done on the innovation, what are the new scientific/engineering elements to be developed that will address the technical risks? What are plans should certain aspects of the approach not work?
3. Provide an experimental plan that clearly describes the research objectives and a discussion of how you intend on achieving the objectives. What set of quantitative metrics will you use to assess the outcome of the innovation research described in the plan? What are the range of values [or specific values] for target specifications that will establish proof of concept in Phase I? Why are these target metrics appropriate, and how do they evidence success.
4. What skills, capabilities and resources will be included in the work to successfully demonstrate feasibility?
5. What intellectual property does the company currently have? Future IP development? What license terms (if any) exist?

Broader Impacts:

1. What is the motivation for the company to take on this project?
2. Clearly articulate how the proposed technology will result in a societal benefit. Which communities will benefit and on what timeline?
3. How will the societal benefits be measured and tracked?

4. What steps are being taken to recognize and minimize the unintended consequences of the proposed technology?

Commercial:

1. What is the background of the team, why is this the right team to execute the commercialization of the proposed innovation?
2. What is the size and scope of the market opportunity? You must identify how you plan to make a scalable, sustainable business from this effort.
3. Who is the customer for the innovation? What is the value proposition for your customer?
4. What does the competitive landscape look like? What is your competitive advantage? (Please search NSF awards database for prior similar technology awards)
5. Which group of customers want the product/technology being proposed?
6. What customer(s) needs or requirements will be satisfied by the proposed product? Is this a need to have or a nice to have?
7. How are the needs and requirement(s) being satisfied now?
8. Why will the customer choose the proposed product over existing solutions?

Be sure to provide supporting evidence for any claims made in the proposal.

To prepare your full Phase I proposal, please follow the NSF SBIR/STTR guidelines and instructions as outlined in the Phase I solicitation. You may use this invitation to submit either an SBIR or an STTR proposal, but not both.

To receive an award, you must meet the **eligibility criteria** as a small business (see above link). Proposals that do not comply with the guidelines or do not meet the listed eligibility requirements outlined in the solicitation may be returned without review.

Please save this email. This email invitation must be uploaded as part of your Phase I proposal submission in the "Additional Single Copy Documents" section of the Research.gov System.

Please also make sure to select the following topic area from the drop-down menu when completing the NSF SBIR Phase I Cover Page for your proposal: Learning and Cognition Technologies (LC). For a list of sub-topic areas, please review our most recent [solicitation topic and subtopic](#).

I recommend starting the required governmental and NSF registrations immediately (See more information about the registrations on the [full proposal page](#)). The System for Award Management (SAM) registration process is free but can take up to a month to complete. You **MUST** have an active SAM.gov registration number to register with NSF and submit an invited full proposal through Research.gov. Sam.gov registration must be renewed annually.

We invite you to join us at an upcoming webinar to learn more about the program and get your questions answered. Details about these sessions can be found here: [Events](#)

We look forward to receiving your Phase I proposal. Please let me know if you have questions.

Thank you,
Lindsay Portnoy

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